



WEEK SEVEN · MODULE ONE

Your Candidacy

How to be chosen, in a world that does not like to be sold to

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

You have the craft, the codes, the toolkit and the map. This week we build the dossier that opens the door, and the composure to sit behind it.

The templates are already in your Vault: the CV, the letter, the interview guide, the agency outreach. This module is the thinking behind them, and the thinking is what an interviewer is actually testing.

Read it with your own CV open beside you, and be prepared to delete a great deal.

CHAPTER I

The paradox

A world that will not be sold to

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand why the ordinary rules of self-presentation invert at this level.

Stop persuading, and start being verifiable.

1.1 · Everything you were taught about applying is wrong here

You were taught to sell yourself. To have a pitch. To be enthusiastic, dynamic, passionate. To say why you would be a great fit and what you would bring to the role.

Every one of those instincts will damage you in this market, and it will damage you in the first ninety seconds, and nobody will tell you why.

Ordinary hiring rewards

Private service rewards

Enthusiasm	Composure. A person who is visibly excited to be near this family is a person who is excited by the wrong things.
Persuasion	Verifiability. They are not weighing your argument. They are checking whether you are safe.
Ambition, stated	Reliability, demonstrated. Ambition is fine and it is not the product. Nobody hires a stranger into their home because she wants to progress.
Being memorable	Being unremarkable, in the specific sense of never being the thing anyone has to think about. That is not a lack of personality. It is the discipline of a professional.
Talking about yourself	Answering, precisely, and then stopping. The silence after your answer is not yours to fill.

THE SENTENCE THAT GOVERNS THE WHOLE WEEK

They are not deciding whether you are impressive. They are deciding whether they will regret you.

Everything in your dossier, everything in your bearing, everything you say in that room, is answering that one question. Impressiveness does not answer it. Very often, impressiveness makes it worse.

1.2 · What this means practically

You do not persuade. You **present, accurately, and let them verify**. The dossier is not an argument. It is evidence, arranged so that a busy person can check it in four minutes and find nothing that worries them.

CHAPTER II

The CV at this level

What it is, and the eleven things that kill it

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Build a CV that survives eight seconds and a reference check.

Handle gaps, short tenures, and the house you cannot name.

2.1 · What it actually is

DEFINITION

The private service CV. A two-page document whose only purpose is to be verifiable, unembarrassing, and clear about what rung you are on. It is not a marketing document and it does not have a personal brand.

2.2 · The structure

Section	What goes in it
The header	Name, city, telephone, an email address that is your name and nothing else, nationality and work authorisation, languages with an honest level. Photograph only where it is the local convention, and if you use one, it is plain, recent, professional and boring.
The line	One sentence. What you are and what rung you are on. "Private concierge, four years in luxury hospitality, currently supporting a private household in Geneva." No adjectives. None at all.
Experience	Reverse chronological. For each: the house or the employer, described at the correct level of confidentiality, the dates, and three to five lines on scope. Scope, not duties. Household size, staff coordinated, residences, budget managed, travel volume.
Education and training	Brief. Including this programme, described accurately, which is to say as an eight-week professional programme, and never as a qualification that it is not.

Section	What goes in it
Languages and practical	Languages with honest levels. Driving licence. Visa status. First aid if you have it, and get it if you do not, because it costs a weekend and it appears on the CV of every serious candidate.
References	"Available on request." Nothing else. You never put a referee's telephone number on a document that will be forwarded.

2.3 · The eleven things that kill it

- **Inflation of any kind.** The consultant has seen ten thousand CVs. She will find it in eleven seconds, she will not confront you, and you will simply never hear from her again.
- **Naming a family.** Even a former one. Even one who would not mind. Doing this on a CV is, on its own, a complete disqualification for anyone serious, and it is the single most common fatal error.
- **Adjectives about yourself.** Passionate, dynamic, dedicated, detail-oriented. They are unverifiable, everybody writes them, and they take up the space where evidence should be.
- **A personal statement of six lines.** Nobody reads it. Replace it with the one line from the structure above.
- **Duties rather than scope.** "Responsible for travel arrangements" is a duty. "Coordinated travel for a family of five across three residences, including private aviation" is scope, and it is checkable.
- **An unprofessional email address, or a personal social media link.** Both are read as a judgement failure, and in this profession judgement is the whole job.
- **Three pages.** Two. If your career genuinely does not fit on two, it is because you have written duties instead of scope.
- **Unexplained gaps.** A gap is fine and is expected, and an unexplained gap is a question mark in a document whose entire purpose is to remove question marks. One line: what you were doing.
- **A pattern of eight-month positions.** There may be excellent reasons for every one of them. It does not matter. Two years is the unit of credibility in this market, and if your CV shows five short roles you must address it in the letter, in one sentence, without defensiveness.
- **Design.** No colour, no columns, no icons, no photograph of a suitcase. It is a document, not a portfolio. Serious houses read seriousness in restraint.

- A typographical error. One is enough. This is a profession in which the entire product is that you notice things.

2.4 · The house you cannot name

Write it exactly like this, and then say nothing more about it:

ON THE CV

Private household, Geneva · 2021 to 2024

Ultra-high-net-worth family, five residences. Personal affairs, relocation and renovation projects, staff and supplier coordination. *Bound by confidentiality. Reference available through the family office.*

That is complete, it is honest, it names nobody, and it tells a serious reader everything they need. And it tells them one more thing, which is that you keep your word.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

The CV is evidence, not persuasion. Two pages, no adjectives, no design.

Never name a family. It is a complete disqualification and it is the most common fatal error.

Scope, not duties. Everything on the page must be checkable.

CHAPTER III

The letter

One page, four paragraphs, and no pleading

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Write a letter that is read to the end.

Address the difficult thing yourself, before they find it.

3.1 · The four paragraphs

Paragraph	What it does
One · why this house, specifically	Two sentences. Something true and specific about this role, this family profile, this city. If it could have been written for any role, it will be read as having been.
Two · what I am	Three or four lines. Your rung, your evidence, your scope. No adjectives, no ambition, no "I have always been passionate about".
Three · the difficult thing	If there is a gap, a short tenure, a career change, an unnameable house, you address it here, yourself, in one sentence, without apology and without a paragraph of explanation. The candidate who raises it first is a candidate who is in control of her own history.
Four · the close	Available for a conversation. Not desperate to be considered. Not grateful for their time. One line, and then your name.

3.2 · The tone

Warm, precise, and entirely without need. Need is audible in writing, it is always audible, and it is the single most damaging quality a candidate can transmit in this market, because a household is buying calm.

Read your letter aloud. If any sentence sounds like it wants something, cut it.

CHAPTER IV

The dossier

What a complete candidacy actually contains

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Assemble a candidacy that is complete before it is requested.

Most candidates send a CV. A complete candidacy, sent when it is asked for and never before, contains rather more, and it is one of the quiet ways a serious person separates herself in this market.

Element	Notes
The CV	Two pages. As above.
The letter	One page. As above.
References	Three, named, briefed, and warned. Chapter V.
Certificates	First aid, driving, food hygiene, any language certification, any professional training. Scanned, legible, current.
Work authorisation	Stated plainly. Do not make an employer discover a visa problem at the offer stage. It will not be forgiven, and it will be remembered by the agency.
A confidentiality statement	One paragraph, in your own words, on how you handle information. Almost nobody includes this, and at this level it is read very carefully indeed, because it is the entire question.
Your code of conduct	From Week 3. Optional, and it is the single most distinctive thing you could put in front of a serious household, and I have never seen a candidate do it.

CHAPTER V

References

The product, and how to protect it

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Choose, prepare and protect your referees.

Understand what is actually asked, and by whom.

5.1 · Choosing

- **Three.** A former employer or their family office. A senior colleague who saw you work. And, if you have one, a supplier or a peer who can speak to how you behave when something goes wrong.
- **Recent, and relevant, and reachable.** A magnificent reference who does not answer the telephone is not a reference.
- **Nobody who will hesitate.** Read Week 6 again. The only question that matters is "would you have her back", and a half-second pause is the answer. If you are not certain of someone, do not use them, however senior they are.

5.2 · Preparing them, which almost nobody does

You call each referee before you give their name. Not after. You tell them what the role is, what the household profile is, and what will most likely be asked. You remind them of two or three specific things you did, because people forget, and a vague reference is a poor one even when it is warm.

And you tell them when to expect the call. A referee who is surprised sounds hesitant, and hesitation is the answer.

5.3 · Protecting them

You never give a referee's details on a document that circulates. You give them when they are asked for, to a named person, for a specific role. Your referees are doing you a favour, and a referee who receives six calls about six roles you did not tell them about will quietly stop being your referee.

CHAPTER VI

The interview

Three rooms, three entirely different conversations

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Prepare correctly for each of the three interviews.

Understand what is being tested in each.

The room	What is actually being tested
The agency consultant	Whether she can put you in front of a family without embarrassment. She is not assessing your soul. She is assessing her own risk. Be precise, be realistic about your rung, be easy to place, and never inflate, because she has heard everything.
The family office	Competence, verifiability, and stability. They will go through your CV forensically, and they will ask about money, contracts, notice periods and visas, and they will not be charmed. Be exact, and have your documents in order, and do not be wounded by the coldness. It is not personal, it is the function.
The principal, or their partner	Nothing on your CV, which they have probably not read. They are answering one question, and it takes them about four minutes: could I have this person in my house every day, for years, without ever thinking about it.

6.1 · The principal's interview, which is the one nobody prepares for

It will feel like a conversation. It will be pleasant. It may last twenty minutes. It may barely touch your experience, and you will leave wondering whether it went well, and this is normal, and it is the most consequential interview of your life.

They are testing four things, and none of them will be asked directly:

- **Composure.** Are you easy to be around. Do you fill silences. Do you laugh a half-beat too eagerly. Are you visibly excited to be here.
- **Discretion.** They will invite you to be indiscreet, warmly, and it will not feel like a test. See Module 2.

- **Judgement.** A situational question, thrown away casually. "What would you do if..." They are listening for whether you would ask, or decide.
- **Whether you want something from them.** Beyond the job. Access, proximity, a story, a life. They have met a great many people who wanted something, and they can feel it across a room.

6.2 · The composure rules

Rule	Why
Answer, and then stop.	The silence after your answer belongs to them. The candidate who keeps talking into it is the candidate who is nervous, and nervousness in a house is a cost.
Never name a family, or hint at one.	Not even a little. Not even if invited. Not even if they name one first. Chapter II, and Week 3, and the rest of your life.
Never criticise a former employer.	Not even the one who deserved it. They are not learning about that family. They are learning what you will say about them.
Ask questions about the work, not about the life.	"How many residences?" "How is the staff structured?" "What does the role find difficult?" Never: who they are, what they do, who else works there in any personal sense.
Do not talk about money first.	If they raise it, answer plainly and without apology. If they do not, it goes to the agency or the family office, which is what those people are for.

CHAPTER VII

The trial day

What it is, what it is not, and what it is really measuring

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Handle a trial correctly, and refuse an exploitative one.

7.1 · The legitimate trial

One day, occasionally two or three. **Paid.** Agreed in advance in writing: the dates, the hours, the rate. This is entirely normal at every level of this profession and you should welcome it, because it is also your interview of them.

7.2 · What it is actually measuring

- **How you are with the staff.** This is the whole trial and almost nobody understands it. The housekeeper will be asked. The driver will be asked. Their answer will outweigh anything the principal thought.
- **Whether you ask or assume.** On a trial day, you ask. About everything, cheerfully, once. Nobody has ever failed a trial for asking. People fail them every week for guessing.
- **What you do when there is nothing to do.** The candidate who stands in a corridor waiting for instructions has failed. The candidate who finds the useful, invisible, unglamorous thing, and does it without announcing it, has passed. This is Week 4, in a room, being watched.
- **Whether you notice.** They will leave something slightly wrong. Nobody will tell you it was deliberate, and very often it was not, and it does not matter.

7.3 · The trial that is not a trial

Two unpaid weeks is not a trial. A "trial" with no agreed end date is not a trial. A trial where you are asked to work alone in the residence on your first day is not a trial and it is a serious warning. Decline, politely, once, and leave. Week 6, Chapter IX.

CHAPTER VIII

Presentation, arrival, and the room

The first eleven seconds, and how to be forgettable in the right way

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Arrive correctly.

Present yourself so that nothing about you is a thought.

8.1 · Appearance

The objective is not elegance and it is certainly not fashion. **The objective is that nobody in the room has a single thought about how you look.** That is a much harder target than looking impressive, and it is the correct one.

Element	The standard
The clothes	Impeccable, unremarkable, well cut, quiet. Navy, grey, black, cream. Nothing new-looking, nothing loud, nothing that requires adjusting when you sit down.
The details	Immaculate shoes, and they will be looked at, by people who look at shoes. Clean, short nails. Hair that does not need touching. Nothing that catches the light.
Scent	None. Not a light one. None. You will be in small rooms and other people's cars for years.
The visible logo	No. Not one. You are not a client of this world, and the candidate who dresses like the family is the candidate who has misunderstood the position, and it is noticed instantly and it is never mentioned.
The bag, the notebook, the pen	A plain notebook and a working pen, and you will use them, because writing things down is the visible proof that you took it seriously.

8.2 · Arrival

You are in the area thirty minutes early, and at the door six minutes early. Not fifteen: fifteen is an imposition, and someone has to deal with you. Six.

You are pleasant to everybody, in order of how little they can do for you. The person at the gate. The housekeeper who opens the door. The assistant who is twenty-three. **Every one of them will be asked, and the candidate who was charming upstairs and brisk downstairs has already failed, and will never know why.**

CHAPTER IX

The offer

What to negotiate, what to check, and what you never do

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Read an offer properly.

Negotiate once, calmly, and on the right things.

9.1 · What must be in writing before you accept anything

Term	Why it matters
Salary, gross, and the currency	And who is the legal employer: the family office, a company, or an individual. This is not a detail. It is your entire legal protection.
Hours, and what "flexibility" means	It will say flexible. Everything at this level says flexible. Ask, plainly, what a normal week actually looks like, and what happens in August, and what happened to the last person in this role.
Days off, and whether they are real	A written day off that is cancelled twice a month is not a day off, and this is the single largest cause of burnout in this profession.
Accommodation, if live-in	What exactly. Whose furniture. What happens to it if the role ends on a Tuesday. Read this clause twice and then read it again.
Travel	How much, how far, how often, and whether it is paid differently. "Some travel" has meant a hundred and forty nights a year to people I have known.
Notice, both ways	And the probation. Symmetry here tells you a great deal about the house.
The confidentiality agreement	You will sign one, and you will read it properly, and you will take two days, and you will take advice if a clause is unclear. Week 3.

9.2 · Negotiating

You may negotiate, once, calmly, on substance, and you will be respected for it if you do it well. Salary, days off, travel load, a probation review at three months.

You do not negotiate with excitement, and you do not negotiate twice. One considered response, in writing, on two or three points at most, with a reason for each, and then you accept the answer gracefully whatever it is. The candidate who reopens the negotiation after it has closed has told the family exactly how the next four years will go.

9.3 · The thing you never do

NEVER

You never use another offer as leverage, and you never accept a role and then continue to interview.

This world is very small, and both of those things will be known within a season, and they will be known by the agency, and the agency has a very long memory and only one asset.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Get the legal employer, the hours, the days off and the travel in writing, before you accept.

Negotiate once, calmly, on substance, and then accept the answer gracefully.

Never use a second offer as leverage. It will be known, and it will follow you.

Glossary

Scope, not duties · The only way to describe experience on a CV at this level. Checkable, quantified, unadorned.

The unnameable house · A confidential former employer. Described by profile, referenced through the family office, never named.

The complete dossier · CV, letter, references, certificates, work authorisation, a confidentiality statement, and your code of conduct.

The briefed referee · A referee you called before giving their name. The unbriefed referee hesitates, and hesitation is the answer.

The three rooms · The agency, the family office, the principal. Three entirely different conversations, testing three different things.

The trial day · Paid, dated, agreed in writing. It measures how you are with the staff and what you do when there is nothing to do.

Forgettable presentation · Dressing so that nobody in the room has a single thought about how you look. Harder than looking impressive, and correct.

The legal employer · The family office, a company, or an individual. Establish this before you sign anything at all.

Self-assessment

Answer in writing, with your own CV in front of you.

1. Rewrite the sentence "they are deciding whether you are impressive" into what they are actually deciding, and explain what that changes about your CV.
2. Go through your own CV and find the adjectives about yourself. Count them. Delete them. What is left, and is it evidence?
3. Take one line of duties from your CV and rewrite it as scope, with numbers.
4. Write the CV entry for a house you cannot name. Four lines. Then read it aloud and check that it names nobody and hints at nothing.
5. Write the third paragraph of your letter: the difficult thing, in one sentence, without apology.
6. Name your three referees. For each, answer honestly: would they hesitate, for even half a second, on "would you have her back"?
7. What are the four things a principal is testing in an interview, and why is none of them on your CV?
8. You are on a trial day and there is nothing to do. Describe exactly what you do in the next twenty minutes.
9. You are offered a role. List, in order, the seven things that must be in writing before you accept.
10. You have an offer and a second interview elsewhere that you think may go better. What do you do, and what would it cost you to do the other thing?

Further study

- **Rebuild your CV this week, from nothing, on two pages.** Not editing the old one. From nothing. Editing preserves the inflation, and you will not see it, because you wrote it.
- **Get a first aid certificate.** It costs a weekend. It appears on the CV of every serious candidate in this profession and its absence is noticed.
- **Call your three referees this week,** before you need them, and ask them plainly whether they would be comfortable. The answer, and the speed of the answer, is information you need now rather than in March.
- **Have someone film you answering five interview questions,** and watch it with the sound off. You are looking for one thing only: whether you look like a person who is comfortable, or a person who wants something.

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